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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 16~06~2026
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing
of other topics in the main exam.

INDIAN LNG TANKER CROSSES HORMUZ; OIL PRICES FALL, STOCKS ADVANCE

US and Iran reach deal to end war, reopen Hormuz

Trump says ‘deal’s all signed’; Israel PM says won’t let Iran have nukes

Parisa Hafezi, Maya Gebeily & Steve Holland
Dubai, Beirut, Evian (France), June 15

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Monday a Memorandum of Understanding aiming to end the war in the Gulf has already been signed by the United States and Iran, drawing calls from his opponents to

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ECONOMY **PAGE 13**
USTR HEADS TO INDIA ON JUNE 23 FOR ‘FINAL TOUCH’ TO TRADE DEAL



A man flashes a victory sign after the deal, in Beirut, Monday. REUTERS

Energy worries far from over, India keeps fingers crossed

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 15

OIL PRICES tumbled Monday after the US and Iran announced that they had reached a peace agreement, to be signed in Switzerland later this week, with Brent futures down about 5% at

E.

around \$83 per barrel by evening. This is the closest the two countries have come to a deal since the West Asia war began in late February, raising hopes of a pick-up in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PM welcomes move, says ensure freedom of navigation, commerce

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 15

UNDERLINING THE “serious economic disruption across the world” and “loss of life in many countries” caused by the war, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday welcomed the “understanding” reached between Iran and the United States.

Later in the day, an Indian Liquefied Natural Gas (LNG) carrier, operated and managed by the State-owned Shipping Corporation of India, crossed

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

NCERT to restore original image of ‘Dancing Girl’

After *Express* report on covered image in textbook

Ritika Chopra
Mumbai, June 15

HOURS AFTER *The Indian Express* reported that the iconic “Dancing Girl” of Mohenjodaro had been covered up in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY

In the Mother of Democracy, the Harappan Election Commission kept the dancing girl figure covered.



[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

US, Iran

publish the text.

His statement came after both the US and Iran announced overnight that they had agreed on terms to end their war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, news that brought relief to markets although the pact may hinge on an end to hostilities in Lebanon and defers talks on Tehran's nuclear programme.

There was no immediate response from Tehran to the report that the agreement had already been signed.

"The deal's all signed. And the strait is already partially opened," Trump said shortly after arriving in Evian, France for a summit of the G7 group of big economies, hailing the agreement to open the Strait of Hormuz, where a three-month blockade of Gulf oil supplies has caused global economic disruption.

An official signing ceremony for the agreement is due to be held on Friday in Geneva, just an hour's drive away from the summit venue in the French Alps.

Asked when the text of the memorandum would be made public, Trump said: "Probably pretty soon. I would say... sometime after Friday... I think sometime in the very near future."

Announcing the deal on his Truth Social platform at around 5:30 pm in Washington on Sunday, Trump wrote: "The Deal with the Islamic Republic of Iran is now complete. Congratulations to all, I hereby fully authorize the toll free opening of the Strait of Hormuz, and simultaneously herewith, authorize the immediate removal of the United States Naval blockade. Ships of the World, start your engines. Let the oil flow".

His post came shortly after Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, whose country has served as a mediator, announced a deal had been struck.

Addressing a press conference later on Monday, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said that with or without a deal, Iran will not obtain nuclear weapons. He also said Israel would keep its forces in southern Lebanon and maintain "freedom of action" against Hezbollah attacks.

"We created a security buffer zone there, we will remain there as long as is needed. Iran wanted us to withdraw from it but I stood firm... we are keeping our freedom of action and we are keeping the security zone to protect (Israel's) northern citizens," Netanyahu said, adding that Israeli forces killed four militants there on Monday.

Netanyahu also acknowledged he and Trump sometime

had their differences, saying that they sometimes do not see eye to eye.

In an early reminder of the agreement's fragility, Israel struck a car with a drone in southern Lebanon, where it has been battling the Iran-aligned Hezbollah movement.

Iran has said the deal requires a full cessation of hostilities there. Israel says it retains the right to act militarily.

A US official said Israeli withdrawal from Lebanon was not a condition of the deal: "The deal is a ceasefire, and it will not be a one-way ceasefire, meaning that if Iran is not able to control Hezbollah, and if they attack Israeli positions or Israeli towns, Israel will have the right to defend themselves and respond."

Oil prices tumbled on the prospect of an end to disruption to global energy supplies, and share prices soared, some hitting new records.

According to accounts from both sides, the agreement would reopen the blockaded strait and extend a ceasefire for a 60-day negotiation period, when contentious issues such as the future of Iran's nuclear programme are due to be decided.

While the terms remain unpublished, US officials say economic benefits to Iran foreseen under the deal are contingent on it satisfying US demands never to build a nuclear weapon.

Vance, speaking to CBS News, said the deal could ultimately end with Iran being given access to a reconstruction fund of up to \$300 billion, funded by its Gulf Arab neighbours, provided it fulfills promises to give up nuclear material.

Iranian officials, who have always denied intending to build a nuclear weapon, say they have given up little and have secured Washington's commitment to lift sanctions, release frozen assets and pay damages for the war Trump launched alongside Israel.

Meanwhile, the immediate fate of the pact could hinge on Lebanon

Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said there must be a complete halt to Israeli attacks against Lebanon and wrote on Telegram that the US bears responsibility for implementing the framework deal. Hezbollah welcomed the deal and said the inclusion of Lebanon reflected Iran's commitment to securing a halt to the war and preserving Lebanon's rights.

Privately, Israeli officials' views of the deal have been negative. One senior Israeli official told Reuters on condition of anonymity that the agreement was "terrible for Israel," and that this assessment was shared throughout the government from Netanyahu on down. **REUTERS**

India's energy worries

maritime traffic through the Strait of Hormuz. But energy and shipping experts, though optimistic, are approaching the development with considerable caution.

India, which depends heavily on West Asian imports to meet its oil, natural gas, and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) needs, is watching the developments closely. Government sources said they hoped the deal would ease energy flows from the region, but are not fully convinced yet. Oil and gas sector insiders are similarly optimistic about the prospect of Iranian oil and gas returning to international markets as part of the agreement, but remain wary of counting on it.

The key concern is most of the deal's terms are still unknown. It remains to be seen how the agreement — if signed — will play out in the fraught waters of the strait, which used to carry a fifth of global oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows before the war began.

Besides, this is not the first announcement promising unimpeded maritime traffic through the strait in the past three-and-a-half months. Earlier announcements came to nothing, and the security situation in the Gulf remained precarious enough for shippers and energy

exporters to hold off.

Even if the deal holds and vessel movements through the strait pick up meaningfully — once shippers feel safe letting their vessels cross the waterway — it will take months for energy flows to recover to pre-war levels. The war forced major Gulf energy producers to shut in large volumes of oil and gas production, as shipping activity in the region ground to an effective halt and they could not evacuate output for export markets.

The disruption has hit India hard. Around 40% of India's crude oil imports, 60% of its LNG imports, and 90% of its LPG imports came from West Asia through the strait. The country's import dependence stands at over 88% for oil, 60% for LPG, and about 50% for natural gas.

"...a signed agreement is not a functioning one, and the sequencing dispute, with both sides insisting the other must move first, remains the main fault line, while Lebanon continues to represent a wildcard that neither Washington nor Tehran fully controls. Markets have seen this playbook before, with an initial rally on the headline followed by a fade as implementation risk re-emerges and there is little to suggest that pattern has been broken," said Claudio Galimberti, Chief Economist

at Rystad Energy.

"A return to normalized market conditions immediately upon signature in Switzerland would look optimistic, as sentiment has clearly improved... but sentiment is not the same as supply. It will take time for production to ramp back up, for logistics to normalize, and for the risk premium embedded in crude prices to dissipate, particularly given that the structural shift implied by the UAE's exit from OPEC+ is not reversed by any near-term diplomatic outcome. If the deal holds, it will therefore represent a step in the right direction, and an important one at that, but still a step rather than a destination," Galimberti added.

Oil prices remain about 20% above pre-war levels, reflecting the market's continued unease over supply risks and transit through the strait. Even if the agreement succeeds and eventually leads to normalisation of traffic through the strait, crude oil prices could take up to a year to return to pre-war levels, beyond any knee-jerk short-term easing, according to Prashant Vasisht, Senior Vice President and Co-Group Head, Corporate Ratings, at ICRA. Gulf energy infrastructure — export terminals, refineries, oil fields, and LNG processing units — could take months, even years in some cases, to return to normal production.

"Beyond the immediate

price action, crude prices could take six months to one year to normalize to pre-war levels given that almost 10-11 million barrels per day of production has been shut in West Asia, besides which some facilities have suffered damages. Additionally, removal of sanctions on Iranian crude would be positive for India given the geographical proximity as well as the higher credit period offered historically, if the same terms continue," Vasisht said.

If shippers resume regular operations through the region, the opening of the strait could allow large volumes of oil, petroleum products, and LNG — currently stranded on vessels in the Gulf — to be evacuated over the coming days, easing the supply situation in the near term. According to some estimates, about 180 million barrels of crude oil and refined fuels, and over 1 million tonnes of LNG, are stranded in the Gulf.

As far back as March 20, international brokerage CLSA, in a report titled "If the war were to end tomorrow...", had said that any news on the opening of the strait could drive a "reflex pull-back in crude oil and LNG prices". But it also foresaw a much tighter post-war supply-demand balance for oil and LNG versus pre-war levels, owing to "risks on pace of restart of production from the Gulf as well as likely new re-stocking demand".

Plea says Punjab failed to implement RTE Act; SC notice to Centre, state

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 15

THE SUPREME Court on Monday sought the response of the Centre and Punjab government to a plea which said the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009 (RTE Act) is yet to be "substantially implemented" in the state despite the law being passed over a decade and a half ago.

A bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice A Mohan issued notice to the two on a plea by former bureaucrat Jagmohan Singh Raju on behalf of KS Raju Legal Trust.

The court also asked Raju, who appeared in person to find out the status of implementation in any backward district of the state, to back up his contention. "We are issuing notice. Meanwhile, just do this. That will help us in understanding the issue," the CJI said.

Raju's plea said despite attempts to seek judicial remedies, including contempt proceedings and representation to the Centre "the state has failed to implement the mandate of Section 12(1)(c) of the RTE Act, which requires admission of children belonging to weaker sections and disadvantaged groups to the extent of at least 25% at the entry level in private unaided non-minority schools".

It added that "this statutory mandate, enacted to operationalise the fundamental right

under Article 21A, has remained substantially unimplemented in the state since inception" and that "the non-compliance by the state of Punjab is neither recent nor incidental, but has persisted since the inception of the Act".

The CJI asked, "Have you been able to identify some schools which are not implementing this?" Raju said it was not a question of one or two schools, the Act has not been implemented in Punjab at all in the last 15 years.

The CJI pointed out that in the proceedings before the HC, the government had filed an affidavit saying 476 children belonging to EWS were admitted in private-aided schools.

Raju said the rule is that 25% of the total number of students admitted in private schools have to be from the EWS quota. "As per government statistics, almost 2 lakh students are admitted at the entry level in private schools every year; 25% of that comes to 50,000," he said.

"What is the policy in Punjab? Do they compensate the school," the CJI asked. Raju said that is the policy universally.

The CJI told him, "We hope you are not fighting for the private schools" for payment from the government.

Raju said, "In 2009, I was joint secretary in the Government of India and was involved in drafting the RTE Act. I have no interest in the private sector. I left IAS." Raju resigned in 2022.

PM on deal

the Strait of Hormuz. According to ship tracking data and industry watchers, LNG Carrier *Disha* was the first vessel to cross the Strait since the announcement of the deal between the US and Iran. The vessel, carrying Qatari LNG, is expected to arrive at Dahej in Gujarat on June 18.

In his post on X after the US-Iran deal was announced, Modi said: "I welcome the understanding reached between the United States and Iran on ending the conflict in West Asia, which has caused serious economic disruption across the world and led to loss of life in many countries."

Modi is in Slovakia's capital Bratislava for a day-long visit as part of his Europe trip.

"India hopes that the implementation of this understanding will help restore peace and stability in the region and ensure the freedom of navigation and commerce. We look forward to deliberations on the remaining issues reaching a sustainable final agreement," he said.

At least 13 Indians, including seafarers, have been killed in attacks during the war in West Asia over the last three-and-a-half months. The most recent was on June 10, when three Indian seafarers died in a US missile strike on a commercial ship.

About 1 crore Indians are estimated to be living in West Asia. According to official estimates,

about 18,000 Indian seafarers, including about 500 who are stranded in the Strait of Hormuz, are currently in the region.

Besides, about 60 per cent of India's energy needs come from the Gulf, and the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz has severely impacted the supply of LPG, LNG, petrol, diesel and fertilisers, leading to rise in prices.

Modi's emphasis on the economic disruption and loss of lives caused by the war signals the stakes involved for Delhi. As does his emphasis on "freedom of navigation and commerce" — a major concern for the country.

The statement also strikes a cautionary note, expressing hope that the "deliberations on

the remaining issues" reach a "sustainable final agreement". Contentious issues, including Iran's nuclear programme, a toll-free Strait of Hormuz and sanctions relief for Iran, are yet to be fleshed out. Also, since Israel is not a party to the pact, Delhi will be keeping a close watch on how the situation unfolds.

Modi will be meeting US President Donald Trump in Evian, France, on Wednesday afternoon, and a clearer picture may emerge. Also, French President Emmanuel Macron has called leaders of the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Qatar to Evian for a separate session on West Asia, on the sidelines of the G7 leaders' summit on June 16-17, and that that will be an opportunity to hear their views.

NCERT

new Arts Education textbook for Class 9, the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) has decided to restore the original image of the Harappan-era bronze figurine.

This newspaper has learnt that changes will be carried out immediately in the digital version of the textbook available on the NCERT website — any copies yet to be printed will also carry the revised image. "From next year, it will be reflected in the hard copy, too," sources told *The Indian Express*.

Following *The Indian Express* report Monday, the Education Ministry is learnt to have sought an explanation from NCERT, after which the autonomous body was nudged to reverse the decision. "If the photo is already there in a Class 6 So-



The Indian Express report dated June 15

cial Science textbook, it doesn't make any sense why the image was retouched for the Class 9 textbook," sources, familiar with the discussions, said.

The question had surfaced earlier as well.

In an interview with *The Indian Express* published on May 27, historian Michel Danino, who headed the textbook development committee for NCERT's new Class 6 Social Science books, disclosed that NCERT had objected to placing the "Dancing Girl" on the opening page of a chapter on the Indus Valley Civilisation because the figurine was nude and could become "controversial".



Danino said he had resisted the move, arguing that the original artefact was displayed at the National Museum in Delhi and routinely taught in schools. While he eventually agreed to shift the image to an inside page and reduce its size, he succeeded in ensuring it remained in the textbook.

NCERT Director Dinesh Prasad Saklani did not respond to requests for comment. It is learnt that in its explanation to the Government on the Class 9 textbook, the Council defended the shading of the figurine's torso on the grounds that it wanted students to use their "imagination".

After 2 failed bids, ISRO to try PSLV launch again soon

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 15

AFTER BACK-TO-BACK failure of its workhorse launch vehicle, the ISRO is likely to attempt another PSLV launch soon.

“As for PSLV, we are planning by the end of June or beginning of July,” said Union Science Minister Dr Jitendra Singh on Monday, on the sidelines of an event to celebrate 12 years of the PM Narendra Modi-led government.

The space agency has not conducted any launches since its last PSLV failed to put the earth observation satellite, EOS-N1, in orbit in January this year. Earlier, in May 2025, the launch vehicle failed to put earth observation satellite EOS-09 in orbit. Both the rockets failed in their third stage.

According to officials in the know of the matter, the flights failed due to certain components that were not manufactured by ISRO. For future flights, the vendor for the components have been changed, they said. While the report of the failure assessment committee has not been made public, the space agency has maintained that the two flights failed due to separate faults.

Apart from the launch of PSLV, the first orbital launch by the private company Skyroot is also expected soon.

When asked about the space agency’s calendar, Singh said that the focus would be on the country’s human spaceflight mission Gaganyaan.

MODI, FICO INK PACTS ON LABOUR MIGRATION, DEFENCE, DIGITAL TECH AMONG OTHERS

India and Slovakia elevate bilateral ties to ‘comprehensive partnership’

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 15

INDIA AND Slovakia elevated their bilateral ties to “comprehensive partnership”, and signed pacts on labour migration, defence, digital technologies, higher education and research, quantum communication and student exchange programme with IIT Delhi after Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s meeting with his Slovak counterpart Robert Fico on Monday.

The comprehensive partnership aims to take bilateral relations to a new level, strengthen existing cooperation mechanisms and explore new avenues for deepening cooperation, both bilaterally and multilaterally, the joint statement said.

After meeting PM Fico in Slovakia’s capital Bratislava, Modi said, “India and Slovakia are also moving forward in close coordination on the global stage. We agree that all disputes and tensions should be resolved peacefully. We will continue to work together with all partners in this direction.” This was a reference to the Russia-Ukraine war, which has been ongoing in Slovakia’s neighbourhood for more than four years now.

The two sides also established a joint working group in counter-terrorism and a consular dialogue. Modi’s visit is the first by an Indian PM to Slovakia since its independence in 1993.

“Today, the Prime Minister (Fico) and I held detailed dis-



Slovak President Peter Pellegrini presents The Order of the White Double Cross (1st Class), the highest state honour of Slovakia, to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in Bratislava on Monday. ANI

cussions on giving new direction and fresh momentum to our cooperation. The progress achieved in our bilateral trade and economic cooperation is a source of satisfaction for us. However, our potential is immense, and our aspirations are even greater. Automobiles, railways, advanced manufacturing, and green technologies are areas of particular interest to us... we have taken several significant decisions today — leveraging our respective strengths — for the welfare of the people of both nations,” Modi said.

Expressing gratitude to Slovakia for its support in finalising the India-EU FTA, PM Modi said: “We will work towards its early implementation so that industries, startups and traders in both countries can derive maximum benefit from it.”

On defence cooperation, he said, “It is a testament to our deep mutual trust and strategic convergence. I am pleased that we signed a Letter of Intent in this vital sector today. This will impart new momentum to joint development, joint production and collaboration between our defence industries.” Many Indian companies in the recent past have signed pacts with Slovak defence companies for joint manufacture in the fields of artillery and armoured systems.

On terrorism, the joint statement said the two leaders “unequivocally condemned terrorism in all its forms and manifestations and strongly condemned the heinous terrorist attack perpetrated in Pahalgam, J&K, on April 22, 2025... they called for concerted international efforts to combat ter-

● OUTCOMES OF PM MODI’S VISIT

- MoU on cooperation in the field of labour migration
- Letter of Intent promoting cooperation in the defence field
- MoU on digital technologies
- MoU on cooperation in the field of higher education and research
- MoU on audio-visual creation
- Establishment of first-ever ICCR Chair in AI at Technical University of Kosice
- MoU between National Institute of Naturopathy, Pune, Ministry of Ayush, and Slovak Health Spa Piestany
- Agreement between IIT Delhi and Slovak Technical University for student exchange programmes, scholarships, research collaboration
- Tourism cooperation between association of tour operators
- Agreement on scientific cooperation between INSA and the Slovak Academy of Sciences
- MoU in the field of quantum communication and critical infrastructure protection

rorism in a... sustained manner”.

The statement said the two leaders agreed to enhance cooperation in the energy sector with a view to promote “energy security, sustainability and resilience through diversification of

energy sources, including nuclear energy and geothermal power”. They expressed their intent to deepen collaboration through joint research, exchange of expertise and capacity-building initiatives in areas of mutual interest. This is especially relevant amid the current situation in West Asia, which has led to an energy crisis in the world.

The two sides also agreed to explore avenues to significantly enhance bilateral trade and two-way investment across sectors such as “automotive, electronics and other advanced manufacturing industries”, leveraging “Slovakia’s well-developed industrial ecosystem” and India’s scale, innovation ecosystem and technological capabilities.

On migration of Indians, the joint statement said the leaders expressed support for orderly, safe and legal mobility of skilled professionals. “They took note of the Comprehensive Framework of Cooperation on Mobility agreed between India and the European Union in January 2026. They welcomed the signing of the MoU on Cooperation in the field of labour migration to facilitate mobility and promote the exchange of information... The two sides also agreed to work towards the early conclusion of a Social Security Agreement, which would contribute to safeguarding the welfare and social protection of working professionals engaged in mobility between India and Slovakia.”

TRIALS UNDERWAY TO STUDY EFFICACY OF CERVAVAC

Serum’s HPV vaccine to be included in immunisation programme after 2027

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 15

THE HPV vaccine developed by the Serum Institute of India, with support from the Department of Biotechnology, is likely to be included in the national vaccination drive after 2027 — once the results of the trials to see the efficacy of its single dose become available.

Dr Rajesh Gokhale, Secretary, Department of Biotechnology, said: “Cervavac is a two-dose vaccine because of which it was not initially launched. The single-dose will come in (to the national programme) after it has been clinically tested.” The study is currently underway with the results expected next year, he said.

While the cost of Cervavac for the government is not known, it costs around Rs 2,000 in the market.

The Health Ministry rolled out the HPV vaccination campaign for 14-year-old girls earlier this year using MSD’s (Merck Sharp & Dohme’s) Gardasil, which already has data to show that a single dose is as efficacious as two doses in this age group.

“A retrospective study can also be conducted (a study where people, who have missed one dose of vaccination, are selected from the population and



Centre rolled out the HPV vaccination campaign for 14-year-old girls earlier this year

their outcomes compared to those who have received the complete two doses) but the current study will take about a year,” said Dr Gokhale.

Union Minister of Science and Technology Jitendra Singh said the current study to test the effectiveness of one dose of the SII vaccine against one dose of MSD vaccine is a better way to do it “for more credibility, especially when it comes to human lives”.

Persistent HPV infection is known to cause nearly 85% of all cervical cancers, the second most common cancer among women, affecting nearly 1.25 lakh women and killing 75,000 each year. HPV vaccination against the four most common strains known to cause cervical cancer has been shown to prevent most infections and thereby cancers.

With an estimated 1.15 crore girls turning 14 each year, the country has enough vaccines for the campaign at present. The GAVI (Global Alliance for Vaccines and Immunisation) has provided around 2.6 crore doses to India, which should be enough for the current as well as next year, after which Serum’s Cervavac may be inducted.

There is an ongoing study — undertaken by ICMR in three of its institutes — that will follow 504 girls who have received one dose of either Serum’s Cervavac or MSD’s Gardasil for a period of two years. The two vaccines will be compared by testing the levels of antibodies that persist against the two most common strains of HPV (16 and 18) in girls given both the vaccines. If the levels are similar, Cervavac will be considered to be equally efficacious.

The National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation (NTAGI) — a body of experts that suggests the government about inclusion of various vaccines into national programmes — had recommended HPV vaccination in 2017 and 2022. The body had recommended the inclusion of the indigenously developed vaccine as a two-dose regimen, to tide over studies on the one-dose vaccine.

NTA admits 'initial shortfalls' after NEET portal breach, ups security

Express News Service
Ahmedabad, June 15

THE NATIONAL Testing Agency (NTA) Monday acknowledged security gaps in the NEET UG-2026 portal, following a cyber breach in which an accused allegedly accessed hundreds of candidates' accounts and attempted to divert refund amounts into his own bank account.

Akash Jain, the newly appointed NTA Joint Director, attempted to reassure students that the administration is taking significant action against those

involved in the NEET paper leak and increasing security measures in the wake of the cyber breach.

"A two-step security feature has been added. We have enabled OTP for mobile phones and are trying to make it an Aadhaar-enabled system. Our job was to refund the amount to the students. We had initial shortfalls in the system, but with this investigation now, we have learned and strengthened it."

Jain's remarks came during a press briefing with Ahmedabad Joint Commissioner of Police Sharad Singhal, to address

public anxieties following the recent cancellation of the NEET-UG due to paper leaks and to announce the arrest of a suspect who was allegedly siphoning off students' exam fee refunds directly from the NTA portal.

"Everything has certain imperfections. A thing cannot be perfect. People may use loopholes. The system we are fighting against, those working against us, they are using technology to such an extent that they remain far ahead of us in technology because they want to commit crimes, and we want to stop it," said Jain.

‘India, Sweden not competing with one another, we actually can complete one another’

INDIA AND Europe do not share a buyer-seller relationship but one of collaboration, says Swedish Ambassador to India **Jan Thesleff**. In an interview with **Divya A.** Thesleff talks about what brings India and Europe together in the present geopolitical context, Indo-Swedish joint defence production plans in Jhajjar and the role that the present India can play in the current world scenario. Edited excerpts:

Sweden was part of PM Narendra Modi's recent four-nation Europe visit. What is your assessment of the 20 hours that PM Modi spent in Sweden?

Personally speaking, that visit is the highlight of my time in India. But more importantly, it's a highlight when it comes to our relations, which date back more than 75 years. So much has happened, so much is evolving in India, and in my country, for good and for bad in the world. It was really time to have this visit to upgrade our relations to a

strategic partnership.

India has many partnerships around the world, but if you look at the partnership that we concluded with India in Gothenburg, it's among the most comprehensive. There was a need for a closer political dialogue with the changing situation in the world, in our neighbourhood, in your neighbourhood. So there was an urgency.

What are the key deliverables for both sides from PM Modi's visit?

Now we not only have a strategic partnership, but a joint action plan. And that goes over five pages, and has a timeline. We have agreed what we should achieve, how, and when. And that is very important. For instance, in the economic field, we will double everything we do. But we will also double what we do in terms of exchanges of researchers, in scientific innovation exchange, and in the number of Indians coming to us.

Today, we have 88,000 Indians with us, almost 1% of our

population. Indians are the biggest immigrant group in Sweden. And we have set out to double all these exchanges. With the FTA, and the changing dynamics in the world, I am convinced we will achieve that. This will happen before 2030.

An important pillar of India-Sweden ties now is defence cooperation. Rather than a buyer-seller relation, it is about co-production and joint ventures. What are the tangible outcomes in that zone?

We have moved far beyond that time when we sent goods to one another. Yes, we still send some goods to one another, but it's much more complicated, involving global supply chains. When I visited an IKEA store in India a few months ago, the blueberry jam stocked there came from Punjab.

When it comes to defence, we are at the forefront in India among foreign countries in defence co-production. As we speak, we are establishing

EXPRESS
interview



JAN THESLEFF
SWEDISH AMBASSADOR TO INDIA

through the Swedish company Saab, a manufacturing plant in Haryana. It is 100% foreign-owned, and will manufacture the Carl-Gustaf rifle. India has been the biggest buyer of these rifles since the 1970s. So the rifles produced by the Swedish company in Jhajjar will cater for the Indian market. And perhaps, beyond that. We will see the first products coming in 2027.

PM Modi's visit happened at a time when India and

Europe are coming together, and have a lot to discuss owing to geopolitical realities. What were the discussions on dealing with global supply chain disruptions?

We are at a point in time where no one is really immune to what happens elsewhere. We have in our neighbourhood, the aggression by Russia on Ukraine going on for four years now. And now we have seen since a little bit more than 100 days, how West Asia is also involved in armed conflict. These things might be far away geographically but they do influence us.

How do you move goods when the seas are no longer open and safe? All this is felt by us, felt by you and felt by the consumers. So a need was felt for a closer coordination, exchange of views, better understanding for the realities of one another.

What also came up in all the meetings is that India, Sweden and Europe are proponents of a rule-based world order.

Chaos, disruptions will not serve us. Three words that came up during the visit were complementarity, predictability and trust.

After the India-EU FTA negotiations concluded in January, there have been greater political engagements between India and EU. What is bringing them closer?

India and Europe were already heading in that direction, but political realities have speeded things up. Because of the situation of the past year, the wars, the tariff issues, the supply chain disruptions... The security situation in Europe and in West Asia was on the agenda.

Were there discussions about how and what role India could play because it is talking to all the sides in both wars that you mentioned?

There was definitely a Swedish recognition that India

has stepped out on the world stage under the leadership of Prime Minister Modi by hosting big events like G20 and now BRICS. We see an India that is more vocal, more present everywhere. Importantly, India has the credibility of being a democracy. What came out in many of the talks were generally that Europe, EU, Sweden and India are also an alliance of democracies, which is something that binds us together.

You say India is now everywhere. As we saw in the joint statement, Sweden lent its support to UN reform.

Sweden lent its support — not for the first time — to UN reforms and India getting a permanent place on a reformed UNSC. There is a recognition of India's rightful place on the world stage.

In this time when we are talking of semiconductors and critical minerals, how would the two countries

collaborate on that front?

In the joint statement, mining is one of the issues that has been highlighted. Sweden possesses unique mining technologies, which will also help India and others to access rare earth minerals. Sweden is one of the top countries when it comes to mining, and also when it comes to the technologies. So there would be collaborations.

In the present context, what do you think makes India indispensable for Europe?

It's the complementarity aspect that we spoke about earlier. We are not competing with one another, we actually can complete one another. When it comes to research, cutting-edge technology, more and more European companies, including from Sweden, are moving part of their research and development to India. The mere scale of India gives access to talent that smaller countries cannot offer. Talent is always related to numbers.

• GEOPOLITICS

US-Iran MoU: The elusive quest for ‘New Middle East’

Disputes over interpretation will begin as soon as the text is released. Implementation will be harder, possibility of breakdown is real. In any case, a profound transition is underway



C RAJA MOHAN

FOR ALL the political turmoil around it, the memorandum of understanding between the United States and Iran, announced by US President Donald Trump on Sunday, could mark an important turning point in the geopolitics of the Middle East. For India, any movement towards defusing the conflict, that threatens to upend its economic stability, is enormously welcome — from the interest of its diaspora to the imperatives of its energy security.

The text of the MoU isn't public yet but it has already triggered strong opposition in Israel, considerable criticism in Washington, and some dissent in Tehran. The resistance in all three capitals suggests that both the US and Iran have made significant concessions to make the agreement possible.

As with any complex negotiation between long-standing adversaries, disputes over interpretation will begin as soon as the text is released. The internal questioning of the agreement will get sharper. The implementation will be even harder and the possibility of breakdown remains real.

Yet the significance of the agreement cannot be dismissed. As US Vice President JD Vance, who is expected to sign the MoU in Geneva on Friday, recently argued, it has the “potential to remake the region and lead to lasting peace”. That may be an overstatement. But there is little doubt that the agreement seeks to redefine relations between Washington and Tehran, which have been locked in confrontation since Iran's Islamic Revolution of 1979.

The idea of a “new Middle East” has been an elusive one. The Oslo peace process in the 1990s, the American invasion of Iraq in 2003, the Arab Spring of 2011, and the Abraham Accords of 2020 were all presented as decisive turning points. Yet each produced outcomes very different from those originally envisaged.

Could it be different this time? The rise of new economic power centres in the Gulf, the accumulation of extraordinary wealth, growing indigenous military capabilities, and the exhaustion produced by decades of conflict are reshaping the Middle East landscape.

To be sure, this is not the first US-Iran agreement. The Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) of 2015, negotiated under US President Barack Obama, fo-



An artwork on the US-Iran peace deal in Mumbai on Monday. ANI

cused primarily on Iran's nuclear programme in exchange for sanctions relief.

The nuclear issue remains central to the current negotiations. But the new MoU appears to go well beyond the nuclear question. It seeks to establish a broader framework for managing US-Iran tensions, reducing the risk of military confrontation, and creating the basis for a more stable regional order. It would also involve phased sanctions relief and support for Iran's economic reconstruction after years of sanctions and the destruction caused by the wars of 2025-26.

The ambition is impressive. The more expansive the agenda, the harder it becomes to negotiate and implement.

Sceptics argue that meaningful change in the Middle East is impossible. Others welcome change but doubt that the region's entrenched rivalries can be overcome. Yet change is the one constant in international politics, and the Middle East is not immune to that fundamental law. The real question is about the nature of change that is now underway.

One important factor is the shifting mood in the US. Across the political spectrum, there is growing fatigue with America's long military involvement in the Middle East. The demand for ending America's “forever wars” now comes from both the left and the right. Equally striking is the growing willingness in Washington to question long-standing assumptions about US policy towards Israel. While Trump has had to walk back his rhetorical bombast before and during the war with Iran, he has also reaffirmed the US role as the principal external force shaping the geopolitics of the region. As in Gaza, so in the Gulf.

Iran, meanwhile, confronts a different reality. If Iranian expansion and regional influence were among the defining stories of the last two decades, the wars of 2025-26

A new framework

For decades, the Middle East has been trapped in recurring cycles of war, proxy conflict, and diplomatic breakdown.

The current negotiations suggest that many regional and external powers are searching for a different framework — one based less on permanent confrontation and more on managing rivalries.

have exposed the costs of that strategy. The economy remains under severe strain. Several regional partners have been weakened by conflict. The risks of direct confrontation with Israel and the United States have become increasingly evident.

Iran has demonstrated significant missile capabilities and shown its ability to threaten critical maritime routes in the Gulf. But you can't live on deterrence alone. Missile cities that Tehran built under its mountains are not the means for Iran's national reconstruction.

Israel remains deeply sceptical of any accommodation between Washington and Tehran. For much of the past decade, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has promoted his own vision of a “New Middle East”, one built around the containment of Iran and, more recently, the prospect of regime change in Tehran. That project no longer appears to command the same support in Washington. At the same time, growing political divisions within Israel raise questions about the future direction of its own regional strategy.

The Gulf states have also moved away from the assumptions that framed their response to the JCPOA as “American appeasement” of Iran. Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates now place a premium on stability and economic transformation. The recent conflict demonstrated how vulnerable their wealth is to war and violence. They have as much interest in de-escalation as Iran does.

For decades, the Middle East has been trapped in recurring cycles of war, proxy conflict, and diplomatic breakdown. The current negotiations suggest that many regional and external powers are searching for a different framework — one based less on permanent confrontation and more on managing rivalries.

Whether such a framework can endure is another matter. Deep distrust between Washington and Tehran remains. Israeli concerns will not disappear. Conflicts in Lebanon, Syria, Iraq and Yemen continue to generate instability.

It may therefore be premature to proclaim the arrival of a new Middle East. But it is not premature to recognise that the old order has been badly shaken. Whatever emerges from the current diplomacy, the region is already in the midst of a profound transition. As the region enters a new phase, India needs to shift from a risk-averse policy to an active role in stabilising regional politics in the Middle East, on its own as well as in coalition with partner nations.

(The writer is a contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express)

JCPOA: Another Iran deal a decade ago, the concessions it secured

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 15

MONDAY'S FRAMEWORK for a peace deal between the United States and Iran has invited comparisons with the 2015 Iran nuclear agreement, which, although signed under different circumstances, tested the limits of their cooperation.

The Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) was signed between Iran and major powers in 2015. It went into effect in January 2016 and put restrictions on Iran's civilian nuclear enrichment programme.

The nuclear option

Five permanent members of the UN Security Council (the US, UK, France, China and Russia) and Germany — collectively “the P5+1” — conducted negotiations with Iran, along with the EU.

An initiative led by then US President Barack Obama, the deal took two years of back-and-forth. It had the approval of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and President Hassan Rouhani, considered reformist and moderate.

Essentially, Iran was to dismantle its nuclear programme and allow international inspections and verification of its commitments. In exchange, it would receive some relief from crippling economic sanctions.

The Obama administration said that Iran needed two key elements to construct a bomb: “Enough highly enriched uranium to produce enough material to construct a uranium bomb and tens of thousands of centrifuges.” Iran agreed not to produce highly enriched uranium and plutonium. The deal also mandated that its Fordow, Natanz, and Arak facilities pursue only medical and industrial research.

At that time, Iran had a uranium stockpile capable of creating 8 to 10 nuclear bombs. As per JCPOA, Iran was to reduce its stockpile of uranium by 98%, and keep its level of enrichment at 3.67% — significantly below the level needed for a bomb.

The third way Iran could build a nuclear weapon was by using weapons-grade plutonium. “The only site where Iran could accomplish this is the Arak reactor, a heavy-water nuclear reactor... under this deal, the Arak reactor will be redesigned so it cannot produce any weapons-grade plutonium,” the Obama administration had said.

Mutual benefit

Iran agreed to implement a protocol

that would allow inspectors from the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), the UN's nuclear watchdog, unfettered access to its facilities and potentially to undeclared sites. The IAEA issued quarterly reports to its board of governors and the UNSC on Iran's implementation.

A body known as the Joint Commission, which included representatives of all parties, monitored implementation.

“What if they try to build a nuclear program in secret? That's why this deal is so important... Iran has committed to extraordinary and robust monitoring, verification, and inspection... (IAEA) will also be verifying that no fissile material is covertly carted off to a secret location to build a bomb. And if IAEA inspectors become aware of a suspicious location, Iran has agreed to implement the Additional Protocol to their IAEA Safeguards Agreement, which will allow inspectors to access and inspect any site they deem suspicious,” the US said.

Citing experts, the US think tank Council on Foreign Relations (CFR), noted that the deal could have prevented Iran from getting nuclear weapons for over a decade: “Many of the JCPOA's restrictions on Iran's nuclear program have expiration dates. For example, after ten years (from January 2016), centrifuge restrictions would be lifted... Some of the deal's opponents faulted these so-called sunset provisions, saying they would only delay Iran building a bomb while sanctions relief would allow it to underwrite terrorism in the region.”

In exchange, the EU, UN, and US all committed to lifting their nuclear-related sanctions on Iran. They also agreed to lift the UN ban on Iran's transfer of conventional weapons and ballistic missiles if Iran only engaged in civilian nuclear activity.

The P5+1 wanted to cap Iran's nuclear programme to the point that if Iran decided to pursue a nuclear weapon, it would take at least one year. CFR said, “U.S. intelligence officials had estimated that, in the absence of an agreement, Iran could produce enough nuclear material for a weapon in a few months.”

In early 2016, the IAEA certified that Iran had met its initial pledges. The US and European nations also unfroze about \$100 billion worth of Iranian assets. However, Trump withdrew from the deal in 2018, calling it “one of the most incompetently drawn deals I've ever seen”, effectively ending the agreement.

For strengthened Iran, a 60-day window of opportunity, a test of resolve



EXPERT EXPLAINS

BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH

BETWEEN THE announcement of the United States and Iran memorandum of understanding and its signing and implementation, lies a four-day shadow.

The full text of the memorandum is to be published after Friday, but the draft is believed to include clauses that Iran would immediately open the Strait of Hormuz to all commercial vessels while the US Navy would remove its blockade within 30 days of the MoU's signing; that the US (and re-

gional allies) would release \$24 billion in Iranian frozen assets, not impose new sanctions on Iran until a final agreement, waive oil sanctions temporarily, and negotiate a reconstruction and development plan (reportedly worth \$300 billion) for Iran within 60 days of the MoU; that the US would militarily withdraw from areas surrounding Iran; and that Iran would never acquire nuclear weapons and maintain status quo on its nuclear programme (no further enrichment) pending a final agreement within 60 days of the MoU's signing.

Deferring the nuclear question

Prior to the war, the US had two principal instruments of leverage, apart from being the overwhelmingly superior conventional and nuclear force. The first was the historic advantage of comprehensive and targeted sanctions forcing Iran out of the global economic order, and the second, more recent, advantage was the severe damage caused to Iran's nuclear facilities in Natanz, Isfahan, and Fordow

Litmus test

● The MoU's 60-day verification period is a greater litmus test for crisis termination than the now-deferred comprehensive nuclear deal. This is especially as there is marked precedent for Iran's acceptance of and adherence to nuclear concessions, from the JCPOA to its continued negotiations till just before the war began.

● There is no precedent, however, for Iran's geopolitical leverage in Hormuz.

during Operation Midnight Hammer (June 2025), which also dislocated Iran's stockpile of 60% enriched uranium.

This pro-US imbalance has been diluted by Iran's gains in the form of its control over the Strait of Hormuz and its ability to threaten regional military and energy infrastructure of US allies.

Iran's reasons

Iranian hardline constituencies have lived through and acquiesced to Iranian concessions on the nuclear question during Ali Khamenei's lifetime. However, in the post-February 28 period, both common Iranians as well as regime hardliners witnessed the dramatic rise of Iranian strategic non-nuclear leverage over Western (including Israel) and Arab powers for the first time, beyond Iran's traditional Axis of Resistance.

This further means that unlike the familiarity of accepting nuclear concessions with Ali Khamenei's blessings, accepting new concessions on a new form of

leverage, under a new Supreme Leader who remains out of public view, is more challenging.

This does not mean that headline resistance will disable an MoU backed by Mojtaba Khamenei; the Leader's decision remains supreme. However, the headline networks seeking to convince the Leader of more stringent positions (as was also common during the senior Khamenei's Leadership) have more breathing space if Iran is seen as conceding a hard-earned position.

So why has Iran agreed to the MoU? For three main reasons, among others.

First, the US/Israeli war has served as a test of the historic, near perpetually imminent, threat of American military action against Iran. Past US Presidents refraining from such action also meant that its effectiveness could not be doubted/tested. That Trump has spent this card and failed allows Tehran to capitalise on a window of opportunity and redouble efforts towards a long-term

nuclear deal.

Second, preliminary terms for urgent economic relief and the removal of the US Navy blockade unarguably present a concession from Washington, as does the unfreezing of Iranian funds (which US Vice President JD Vance had said would not happen until a deal was reached, on June 12). Losing this window of American concessions is seemingly not in Tehran's interest, especially as Iran has (thus far) succeeded in keeping both its missile programme as well as its support for the Axis out of the MoU.

Third, Tehran's responses to Israeli attacks on Lebanon prove that Iran's geographic advantages and its missile/drone stockpile allow it to return to pre-MoU conditions whenever it deems American/Israeli actions as breaching terms. Theoretically, given that the MoU places no limit on Iranian drone capabilities or missilery, Iran's commitments exist only on paper and are subject to US adherence to MoU terms.

The Editorial Page

TUESDAY, JUNE 16, 2026

In West Asia pause, questions for India, especially about its place at the table

Iran-US framework pact is a relief. Work lies ahead

THE FRAMEWORK agreement between Iran and the US to negotiate a deal comes as a relief. Thousands of lives have been lost across West Asia in the last three-and-a-half months. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the counter-blockade by the US triggered an economic shock, reminiscent of the Covid days. Oil prices have fallen, and stock markets worldwide have rallied after the announcement of the framework agreement. However, amid the optimism, it is important to remember that what has been agreed to is not a final deal but a framework to address longstanding issues. The prospect of a return to unrestricted shipping is heartening. But that, too, could take time to materialise and will depend on how safe shipping companies and insurers feel. Still, an open strait — through which roughly a fifth of the world's oil and gas passes — is good news. Its reopening, according to Trump, will depend on the signing of the final agreement, scheduled for Friday.

If the past two weeks are any indication, it takes very little for all sides to resume hostilities. Israel has already declared that it will not withdraw from Lebanon, while Tehran has demonstrated its willingness to call Tel Aviv's bluff and retaliate — militarily and by closing the Strait of Hormuz — if Lebanon is excluded from the terms of the ceasefire. Negotiating the details of Iran's nuclear programme, the release of frozen assets, sanctions relief, and securing the strait from future conflicts are even more difficult long-term challenges. For the US, a legitimate question, given that shipping through the Strait of Hormuz is only a return to the status quo ante, is: What exactly has Trump achieved? Republican hardliners have been opposing any deal short of a Carthaginian one, arguing that a compromise would weaken America's standing in the region. Israel, too, is deeply divided. Benjamin Netanyahu's far-right cabinet members have denounced the framework pact as a strategic failure. In Iran, hardliners within the IRGC oppose any agreement they perceive as surrendering leverage without securing meaningful guarantees, even as the country is in need of sanctions relief and reconstruction funding — both of which are unlikely to materialise without US acquiescence.

With millions of Indians working across the Gulf, thousands serving at sea, and households grappling with high fuel and LPG prices, the crisis is not a distant one for New Delhi. It should lend its support to the peace process. Without sustained engagement, the current pause risks becoming little more than an interlude in a cycle of instability.

Dancing Girl, meet modest imagination

WHAT DOES the Dancing Girl of Mohenjo-daro — the 4,500-year-old bronze artefact on display at Delhi's National Museum — denote? The refinement of the Harappan civilisation, of course; its sophisticated knowledge of metallurgy. But also, the NCERT now seems to insist, immodesty. The inaugural Class IX art education textbook features an image of the figurine with its bare torso covered with a sheath, ostensibly to make it age-appropriate. The Dancing Girl has featured in NCERT's history textbooks for over 25 years before this. The move is remarkable not just for its prudishness but for what it reveals about pedagogical philosophy: That students must be protected from complexity, ambiguity, and the full texture of their own civilisation.

In recent years, through successive revisions, textbooks have been streamlined, historical emphases reordered and contentious subjects pared back. NCERT has cited a need for rationalisation of syllabi, and what its director D P Saklani said in 2024, justifying the deletion of the Gujarat riots and the violence after the Babri Masjid demolition from the Class XII Political Science textbook: "To create positive citizens, not violent and depressed individuals." The altered Dancing Girl belongs to the same sensibility. Instead of trusting students to understand context — that artistic nudity in an archaeological artefact is neither scandalous nor unusual — it removes the possibility of the encounter altogether. This sits uneasily with the NEP's ambition of fostering critical thinking: Education that aspires to cultivate independence of thought must make room for knowledge and context, not smoothen out every faultline, conflict and contradiction.

The impulse is also striking for what it communicates about women and their place in public life. At a time when more women than ever before are entering universities, workplaces, politics, and other public institutions, wearing their individuality in thought and attire, claiming spaces that often remain unequal or unwelcoming, the decision to cover up one of the most celebrated examples of ancient South Asian art sends an unfortunate message. The Dancing Girl has been significant not because it conforms to a blindfolded standard of modesty but because it embodies poise, confidence and unmistakable presence. If the task of education is to equip young people to engage with the world as it is, then NCERT would do better to trust both students, and women — both contemporary and millennia old — with a little more agency.

WRITE this from Srinagar on the eve of Muharram. Black flags wave in the summer wind through neighbourhoods in parts of the city. On the boulevard that overlooks the Dal Lake there towers a billboard-sized portrait of Iranian leaders staring down upon us. It is an unsettling backdrop against which to meditate upon the American-Iranian blueprint for peace being stitched. A deal that troubles rather than reassures.

US President Donald Trump can claim victory, as he has already done. And he deserves to: Purely on the basis of this day alone. The guns may fall silent. Markets will stabilise. Oil shipments through the Gulf will no longer navigate minefields. That is laudable. But the foundational faultlines that set up this crisis — Iran's ambitions and proxies in the region, Israel's vulnerabilities and security obsessions, the Gulf's volatility and Trump's hubris — remain exactly as they were yesterday. What has been bought by this breathing space is time, masquerading as victory.

While this deal breaks a war, it doesn't settle the numerous questions that led to it. Lebanon remains on a wire. Hezbollah's future is still up for grabs. Israel has said it needs the freedom to operate. And the nuclear issue isn't solved, it's been kicked under the table — a 60-day delay where there should have been a resolution. A ceasefire suspends all these concerns. It doesn't answer any of them. And it can't prevent other nations from

drawing their own conclusions about deterrence and nuclear weapons and their utility.

We, in India, should feel deeply concerned. For more than two decades, New Delhi has invested in Washington — emotionally, politically and strategically — on the belief that when push came to shove America would remember just how significant that equity was and what it said about India's stake at the highest table. Today it did not. Indian sailors lay vulnerable. Indian lives were risked and lost as the fight expanded. Indian commerce was throttled at a time when our economy depends more than most upon its engines running; the livelihoods of millions of Indians we cherish in the Gulf teetered on a knife's edge. None of that registered in the fevered pitch of Trump's social-media worldview when it sat down to negotiate a pause. Instead, America dialled Islamabad. The very same deep state that has managed four decades of terror at India's border was delivered centrality in American decision-making without the slightest pause for how that upgrade would be perceived in New Delhi. Adversaries are blind. America is India's friend. But a friend who doesn't notice you are in the room anymore will hurt far worse than an adversary eventually. Because weakness invites aggression. Indifference allows it to flourish, free from question.

We have insulated ourselves comfortably to Pakistan being a



AMITABH MATTOO

Proximity is not leverage, access is not influence and the visibility that you or others have does not translate into strength if the country that needs to heed that visibility is not also willing to use it

A 12-year story of peace and progress in Bastar



VISHNU DEO SAI

THE PERIOD under Prime Minister Narendra Modi has brought major changes in India. The country has made significant progress in security, roads, electricity, housing, digital services, and welfare schemes, in a golden period for India's security and development. Strong leadership has helped the country move forward with confidence.

For Chhattisgarh, this was a significant change. Bastar and other tribal areas earlier faced Naxalite violence, poor roads, and lack of basic facilities. Today, the situation is improving, with better security, roads, and welfare schemes bringing hope.

A decade ago, India faced terrorism and Left-Wing Extremism. The government took strong steps to overcome these challenges. The removal of Article 370 strengthened national unity. Efforts against Naxalism reduced violence, including in Bastar, and development started reaching neglected regions.

In Bastar, under Niyad Nellanar Yojana, the benefits of 43 schemes from 17 departments reach 525 villages near security camps. These camps are being converted into Veer Shaheed Gundadhur Seva Deras for better service delivery.

Central government schemes have played a major role in the past 12 years. Under PM Awas Yojana, 2.43 lakh urban houses have been approved and 2.16 lakh completed in Chhattisgarh. PM Janman Yojana supports Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups with housing, roads, healthcare, and education. The Dharti Aaba campaign improves Anganwadi centres, schools, and local services in tribal villages.

Under the Swasthya Bastar campaign, 36 lakh people have been screened, 4.96 lakh examined, and 5,600 referred. Through Mahatari Vandan Yojana, 69 lakh women receive Rs 1,000 monthly, with over Rs 17,500 crore transferred.

PM-KISAN supports farmers. Krishak Unnati Yojana saw the procurement of 14.1 million metric tons of paddy in kharif marketing year 2025-26 with a Rs 33,431 crore support price and Rs 10,324 crore input assistance.

Under PM Surya Ghar, 61,000 homes have rooftop solar systems, reducing costs

and promoting clean energy. A single-window system improves ease of doing business and the investment climate.

The Bastar Olympics and Bastar Pandum promote tribal culture. Chitrakote is being developed as a major tourist site, creating jobs. Direct benefit transfers have ensured that money reaches beneficiaries without delay or leakage. Mobile connectivity and internet access in remote villages have helped people access government services more easily.

Bastar is also witnessing social and economic change through self-help groups, forest-based livelihood, and co-operative models. Minor forest produce collection and value addition are increasing income for tribal families.

Digital agriculture initiatives like Agri-Stack and Farmer Registry are improving transparency and reducing delays in subsidy delivery. Farmers are now able to access crop insurance, MSP benefits and soil health information more efficiently.

Skill development programmes are preparing youth for national and global opportunities. Training in new-age sectors such as IT and AI is helping young people become job-ready.

Better roads, electrification and drinking water supply are ensuring that basic needs are met in previously remote villages. Government schemes are reducing inequality between urban and rural areas.

The combined impact of central and state initiatives is visible in every sector of Bastar, which is emerging as a model of transformation. There is trust in governance, active participation by citizens and growing opportunities for the future. As India progresses towards Viksit Bharat 2047, Chhattisgarh remains committed to ensuring that the benefits of development reach every citizen.

The transformation of Bastar shows how focussed governance and welfare delivery can change lives in even the most difficult regions, creating a safer and more hopeful future for all. This progress is a result of sustained efforts, strong leadership, people-centric policies, and coordinated implementation across levels of governance.

The writer is Chief Minister of Chhattisgarh



VISHNU DEO SAI



The Ideas Page

TUESDAY, JUNE 16, 2026

Only fraternity can bridge communal divide, douse flames of hate



ASHOK LAVASA

A DAY after the Citizens for Fraternity (CFF) held their first meeting to discuss ways to douse the spreading communal fire in our society, I saw a photo in the newspapers of the first responders during the rescue necessitated by the deadly fire in Hauz Rani. Their names: Mohammad Afzal, Wasim Raja, Mohammad Shoaib, Amir Khan. Others named in an *Indian Express* report were Mansoor, Israr Khan, and the man who stood out amid this tragedy, Riyazuddin Mansuri and his son Armaan, who spread mattresses on the road for those trapped inside the building to jump to their safety.

There were also 10 policemen — Kartar, Deepak, Vikram, Dinesh, Rampal, Sandeep, Hargyan, Premchand, Jitendra, and Raviranjan — who helped victims out of the blaze unmindful of the injuries they themselves suffered because they didn't wait to get into a safer gear that would minimise their risk. The police are a much-abused lot in our system, and the fellow citizens who saved many lives belong to a community that feels victimised in its own country.

The CFF is a new effort to address an old problem. Set up as a result of a dialogue between prominent Muslim citizens with Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) *sar-sanghchalak* Mohan Bhagwat and senior office-bearers, it is an attempt at finding ways to bridge the growing communal divide in India that has demoralised the minorities. Perhaps the need to communicate was inspired by Bashir Badr, who passed away recently, who said, “*main chup raha to aur ghalat-fahmiyan baDhin, vobhi suna hai us ne jo main ne kaha nahin*” (Because of my silence, our misunderstanding grew, He even heard that which I never said)."

The CFF meeting was attended by citizens belonging to different communities, the president of the Indira Gandhi National



ILLUSTRATION: C.R SASIKUMAR

Centre for the Arts and the *akhil bharatiya sampark adhikari* of the RSS.

The focus of the dialogue was fraternity. It was argued that while liberty and equality were fundamental rights supported by enabling legislation, fraternity required a serious, sincere and subtle approach to provide a healing touch without scraping old wounds. It was emphasised that liberty and equality were justiciable but fraternity would come about only when there was a deeper understanding of each other's way of life, belief system, scriptures and culture.

The pity is that the need to discuss this remains as acute today as it did eight decades ago, when fraternity and communal harmony were debated in the Constituent Assembly.

On August 15, 1947, Gandhi didn't watch the flag hoisting in Delhi; he chose to be in Kolkata, staying in riot-torn areas “spreading mattresses” to subdue the communal conflagration. For him, communal harmony was an article of faith as he believed the true measure of a civilised nation's commitment to fraternity lay in how secure its smallest or

Ambedkar defined fraternity as 'a sense of common brotherhood of all Indians' and warned that without this psychological solidarity, the structural rights of liberty and equality would be 'no deeper than coats of paint'

most vulnerable communities felt.

B.R Ambedkar introduced fraternity into the draft of the Preamble as he thought this was a core political necessity for a deeply divided society. Addressing the Assembly on November 25, 1949, he warned that political democracy would collapse if India failed to establish a social democracy. For him, liberty, equality, and fraternity were inseparable principles as they formed “a union of trinity in the sense that to divorce one from the other is to defeat the very purpose of democracy. Liberty cannot be divorced from equality, equality cannot be divorced from liberty. Nor can liberty and equality be divorced from fraternity. Without equality, liberty would produce the supremacy of the few over the many. Equality without liberty would kill individual initiative. Without fraternity, liberty and equality could not become a natural course of things. It would require a constable to enforce them.”

Ambedkar defined fraternity as “a sense of common brotherhood of all Indians” and warned that without this psychological solidarity, the structural rights of liberty and equality would be “no deeper

than coats of paint”. He wasn't alone in underscoring this as many others in the Assembly emphasised that while the Constitution could map out organs of the state, it couldn't legislate affection. It was widely acknowledged that fraternity was the emotional glue required to hold a diverse, multi-religious, and economically unequal India together and that it represented a moral principle that must be lived daily.

The Constituent Assembly exhaustively debated fraternity and communal harmony as this reflected the real anxiety during the Constitution-making process between 1946 and 1950. Instead of talking about harmony as an abstract moral concept, the Assembly under the leadership of Nehru and Vallabhbhai Patel, the chairman of the Advisory Committee on Minorities, voted to abolish separate electorates for minorities and dropped political reservation based on religion entirely, choosing to protect minorities instead through cultural and educational rights (Articles 29 and 30), allowing them to preserve their distinct languages, scripts, and institutions without separating them politically.

It is an understanding of this distinct script and scriptures that the CFF aims to promote by taking this movement to the states and districts. It is encouraging that the push comes from the RSS. It will be interesting to see how many “mattresses” the RSS throws to cushion the impact of the vitriolic speech of those in power. Will it publicly support the action of “Mohammed” Deepak who defended an elderly Muslim shopkeeper from a right-wing mob in Kotdwar, and suffered near-ostracisation, leading to a near-collapse of his business? The RSS, the “world's biggest NGO”, would do well, in furtherance of its avowed commitment to nation-building, to actively participate with the CFF and similar organisations to build a society based on the values of “fraternity, awareness, dialogue, respect, justice, and integration”.

Let us heed the poet of love, Bashir Badr: “*dushmani ka safar ik qadam do qadam, tum bhi thak jaoge ham bhi thak jaenge*” (Even a step or two in the journey of enmity will exhaust both of us)."

The writer is a former election commissioner

At G7 meet, India can be the voice of developing countries



AJAI MALHOTRA

AT FRANCE'S invitation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will join world leaders for the G7 Summit at Evian-les-Bains to discuss issues shaping economic power, technological advantage and development. The G7 is no longer the dominant body it was in the mid-1970s; the rise of emerging economies and the 2008 financial crisis changed that. Yet, it remains influential in setting standards and shaping financial flows, though far less cohesive today. Differences over trade, climate finance, industrial subsidies, energy policy and ties with Russia are evident, especially between the US and others. Evian will involve negotiations as well as coordination amongst G7 members. For India, that creates greater scope for issue-based partnerships.

Bilaterals, especially between PM Modi and US President Donald Trump, will attract intense attention. While leaders will discuss hotspots like West Asia and Ukraine, France has deliberately placed economic imbalances and the risks of fragmentation in the global economy at the centre of the agenda, which will focus on economic security, artificial intelligence, the energy transition, climate finance and development.

As one of the largest economies, a growing energy market and technology hub, India is affected by and increasingly central to these debates. It will bring to the table concerns shared by many emerging and developing economies.

Indian and G7 interests converge on critical minerals. Securing lithium, cobalt, nickel and rare earth supplies is central to the energy transition and advanced manufacturing. India's efforts complement those of G7 economies to reduce supply-chain dependence on China for clean energy and defence technologies. Its market size and processing capacity make it an important node in emerging mineral partnerships.

Artificial intelligence raises questions of governance, standards, safety and technological leadership. It is also becoming an energy issue since data centres and advanced computing drive electricity demand. India's experience with digital public infrastructure gives it a credible voice in shaping the debate.

Energy security is another central theme. The clean energy transition is rewriting investment and industrial policy worldwide, yet hydrocarbons still underpin growth. India embodies this duality. It has expanded renewable deployment at scale with its fuel choices guided by affordability and security of supply, not geopolitical pressures. A major energy consumer, India can speak with authority from experience.

On economic security, India's interest lies in resilience that broadens options rather than narrows them. Security pursued through exclusion produces the fragmentation it seeks to prevent. Advanced economies are resorting to forced trade: The selective use of leverage, sanctions and coercion to influence with whom, and sometimes at what price, other countries trade. The result is a growing gap between the free-trade principles they once professed and the market-distorting policies they practise.

Turning to development, much of the Global South faces rising debt obligations and widening financing gaps. Reform of multilateral development banks remains a pressing concern.

On climate finance, developed countries agreed at Baku in 2024 to mobilise at least \$300 billion annually by 2035. Even that falls well short of what is needed, while much arrives as loans, not grants. What developing countries lack is not commitment to climate action but the resources to do so. Climate finance has long been part of common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities. India must recall that principled position while sharing its experience in matching climate ambition with overriding development priorities.

A related concern is the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) that now taxes steel, aluminium, cement and fertiliser imports according to emissions embedded in their production. Its impact falls disproportionately on developing-country producers, including India, whose industries remain coal-dependent because the finance and technologies for a faster transition are unavailable. Presented as climate policy, CBAM operates as a trade barrier protecting EU industries. Climate transition cannot be advanced by taxing countries the developed world has committed to help. There is something perverse about first underfunding the green transition and then taxing those unable to afford it.

Standards, frameworks and partnerships being discussed at Evian on technology, supply chains and critical minerals will shape the global environment. India's interest lies in influencing these debates before outcomes harden into practices that affect the wider world. The G7 Summit participation, months before it hosts the BRICS Summit, reflects multilateral engagement without exclusive alignment.

India should approach Evian as a participant helping shape outcomes. Few countries today can engage comfortably with advanced and developing economies while carrying influence with both. In a world where today's discussions become tomorrow's rules, it is far better to help write them than to inherit them.

The writer is a former diplomat



PRELIMINARY DEAL COULD STILL COME APART AND NEGOTIATIONS ARE LIKELY TO BE COMPLEX, SAY EXPERTS

Art of the Deal: Strait, but with Twists

Iran n-stockpile, recovery of energy supply, Lebanon: Challenges loom

Jon Gambrell & Elena Becatoros
Dubai, June 15

THE US and Iran reached an initial agreement Monday that would extend their shaky ceasefire and lead to the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, but significant challenges remain, including whether Israel will continue its offensive in Lebanon. Details of the agreement were not immediately released, but it appeared it would not be implemented until it is signed, which mediator Pakistan said would happen Friday in Geneva. Until then, shipping will likely remain restricted in the strait.

Israel's Defense Minister Israel Katz said Monday the country wouldn't withdraw from land seized in Lebanon, where Israel is fighting Hezbollah. A spokesman in PM Benjamin Netanyahu's office said Israel will continue to defend itself against any threat to its security. That alone could scupper the deal, since Iran has insisted any agreement to end the war include an end to fighting in Lebanon.

But the agreement also faces other major challenges. It gives just 60 days to decide what to do about Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium and its nuclear program.

The closure of the strait — through which a fifth of the world's oil and natural gas passed before the war — and the blockade sent fuel prices skyrocketing, and its effects rippled through economies. It will likely take months before energy companies can resume operations to the point of meeting the world's demand, according to energy experts.

Iranian and US officials will hold preparatory meetings in Doha, Qatar, this week before the signing, said a diplomat with

● PRESSURE POINTS

● Whether Israel will continue its offensive in Lebanon. Israel's Defense Minister said the they wouldn't withdraw from land seized in Lebanon.

● Deal gives just 60 days to decide what to do about Iran's stockpile of highly enriched uranium, its n-programme.

● Strait of Hormuz won't open until deal is signed.

● Months before energy companies can resume operations, meet global demand.

Vance: No fund transfer to Iran for signing deal

US Vice President J D Vance said on Monday no funds would be released to Iran for signing an agreement and opening Hormuz and that the framework's text would be shared this week. In an interview on ABC, Vance said signing the MoU would not trigger release of frozen assets. "If we see Iranians making, for example, taking action to eliminate stockpile of enriched material, then yes, sanctions relief will follow. If we see Iranians taking action to allow the kind of verification regime we need to see to know they're not going to build a nuclear weapon, yes, sanctions relief will follow."

REUTERS

direct knowledge of the talks.

The success of the deal rests at least partially on what happens between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon. Katz said Israel plans to stay "indefinitely" in land it holds in Lebanon, Syria and the Gaza Strip.

Katz also threatened if Iran attacks Israel over its strikes in Lebanon, Israel will strike Iran with "great force."

AP



A woman waves an Iranian flag in downtown Tehran on Monday after a memorandum of understanding was reached between Iran and US. AP

Our struggle is not over, says Netanyahu

Rami Ayyub & Maayan Lubell
Jerusalem, June 15

WITH THE US and Iran reaching a memorandum of understanding aiming to end the war, Israel Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Monday that Israel has been saved from "annihilation" "but our struggle is not over, we will continue to thwart threats in the region."

As US President Donald Trump seeks to extricate himself from the war, Netanyahu said, "Sometimes Trump and I do not see eye to eye, we are partners, often we agree and sometimes we disagree."

On Lebanon, he said, "We will remain in 'buffer zone' as long as we need to, we will maintain freedom of action to thwart attacks."

Netanyahu bet that his joint war alongside Donald Trump would topple Iran's clerical rulers and bolster himself ahead of elections at home,

Two Israeli officials said Tel Aviv was caught by surprise last week when Trump first said a deal was close. They acknowledged Israel has had little success in influencing the talks.

as the architect of a US-Israeli alliance that would reshape the Middle East.

But in private conversations, the frustration is clear. The preliminary agreement is "terrible for Israel," said a senior Israeli official. "And there is no one in Israeli leadership who views it otherwise, from the PM to the chief of staff."

Washington says that over the next 60 days, when a ceasefire is in place, it will negotiate full terms that will address US and Israeli concerns, especially over Iran's nuclear programme.

But Israeli officials told Reuters they thought the negotiating period was likely to be extended, tying Israel's hands from taking military action, while its concerns remain unresolved. Netanyahu and Trump have clashed over Israel's refusal to constrain its pursuit of Hezbollah in Lebanon, where a cessation of hostilities is a key Iranian demand. The deal would reopen Hormuz, leaving the fate of Iran's nuclear programme to be resolved during a 60-day negotiation period. Two other issues that both leaders declared as justifications for the war at its outset — curbing Iran's missile pro-

Hezbollah welcomes MoU

Hezbollah on Monday welcomed the MoU between the US and Iran, saying it had resulted in a comprehensive ceasefire across all fronts, including Lebanon. In a written statement, the group warned Israel it would not accept any attacks that violate Lebanon's sovereignty or targeted its people. It said Lebanon's inclusion in agreement reflected Iran's commitment to ending the war.

REUTERS

gramme and ending its support for regional armed groups — are not thought to be on the agenda during those talks.

Three Israeli officials said Israel sees it as likely the 60-day pact will be extended to 90 days. Two other Israel officials said Israel was caught by surprise last week when Trump first said a deal was close. They acknowledged Israel has had little success in influencing talks.

REUTERS

WHAT THE U.S. AND IRAN HAVE AGREED TO

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN

- Pak PM Shehbaz Sharif said both sides had declared an immediate and permanent end of all military operations.
- All sides have said the MoU will be signed in Switzerland on Friday. Iran's Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said the memorandum would then be published.
- Iran and the US have both said Hormuz would start to reopen and the US blockade on Iranian ports start to lift after signing.
- Both sides have said negotiations on more difficult further areas of dispute — notably Iran's nuclear issue and US sanctions on Iran — will be conducted over the next 60 days.

STRAIT OF HORMUZ & BLOCKADE OF IRAN PORTS

- US President Donald Trump said the Strait of Hormuz would be reopened Friday and he had ordered a lifting of the blockade on Iranian ports.
- A senior Iranian official said the strait would be reopened "to all commercial vessels" once the MoU is signed.
- Iran's semi-official Fars news agency reported that under the MoU, marine traffic through the strait would be regulated by Iran in coordination with Oman.

IRAN'S N-PROGRAMME

- Both sides have said Iran agrees it will neither produce nor acquire nuclear weapons — a promise Tehran has been making repeatedly for decades.
- The senior Iranian official said pending a final agreement Iran would freeze its nuclear activity, refraining from further uranium enrichment or the expansion of nuclear facilities.
- The senior official said the US had agreed Iran could dilute its stockpile of highly enriched uranium inside Iran under a future comprehensive agreement.
- Trump said Saturday there was no urgency to extract Iran's nuclear stockpile and that the US would retrieve it "when all is calm".
- Trump said there would be a strong inspections regime for Iran under any deal, but didn't give specifics.

● US Senator Lindsey Graham said any final deal on Iran's n-programme would have to be reviewed, approved by Congress.

SANCTIONS AND FINANCIAL IMPACT

- The senior Iranian official said the US had agreed not to impose any new sanctions on Iran until a final deal was reached.
- They added the US would waive oil sanctions on Iran for a specified period and that after final agreement all US & UN sanctions would be lifted to an agreed timetable.
- The senior Iran official said the US had agreed to release \$25 bn of Iran's frozen assets, including via direct cash transfers, cooperation among regional countries, and financial credit lines.
- Washington, in coordination with regional allies, would prepare a reconstruction & development plan for Iran, to be negotiated & agreed with Tehran in 60 days, they added.
- Trump said Iran would not be provided with cash but that sanctions could potentially be lifted.

● Pain point Hormuz



SOURCE: MARINE TRAFFIC

LEBANON

- Sharif said the immediate and permanent end of all military operations would include Lebanon.
- Secretariat of Iran Supreme National Security Council said military ops would stop permanently Monday night including in Lebanon.
- Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said there must be a complete halt to Israeli attacks against Lebanon.
- Israel Defence Minister Israel Katz said "the Israeli military would remain in security zones it has captured in Lebanon, Syria and Gaza and that PM Benjamin Netanyahu had made this clear to Trump."

REUTERS

WORLD LOOKS FORWARD TO PEACE AND STABILITY

"We are clear that toll-free freedom of navigation must now be restored in the Strait of Hormuz ... Iran must never have a nuclear weapon."

KEIR STARMER, BRITISH PM

"This agreement must allow for the urgent and unconditional reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, which the international mission established with the UK is ready to support."

EMMANUEL MACRON, FRENCH PRESIDENT

"Italy, as in the past, is ready to support the diplomatic process for a comprehensive agreement. We are ready ... to contribute to an international naval presence to accompany the full reopening of the Strait of Hormuz."

GIORGIA MELONI, ITALIAN PM

"Continued restraint and constructive engagement will be essential to... secure a lasting agreement."

ANTHONY ALBANESE, AUSTRALIAN PM

"... An important development for peace and tranquility in our region, and I welcome it with satisfaction... I underscore the need to avoid rhetoric."

TAYYIP ERDOGAN, TURKISH PRESIDENT

"This (agreement) can pave the way towards a reinvigorated global economy and a more secure Middle East. It is crucial to implement it with determination."

FRIEDRICH MERZ, GERMAN CHANCELLOR

"Priority now is swift, full implementation (of agreement) by all parties ... Freedom of navigation must be restored toll-free. This is essential for regional stability and the global economy."

URSULA VON DER LEYEN, EUROPEAN COMMISSION PRESIDENT

"Japan strongly hopes free, safe navigation through the Strait of Hormuz will be ensured in practice."

SANAE TAKAICHI, JAPAN PM



US President Donald Trump and French President Emmanuel Macron on the sidelines of G7 Summit in Evian on Monday. AP

Associated Press

Evian-Les-Bains, June 15

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump started his visit to the G7 Summit on Monday by hailing his agreement aimed at ending the war with Iran as a potential breakthrough for global security.

At a meeting with French President Emmanuel Macron, Trump declared it was promising — albeit not a guarantee — that the US was finally turning the page in its relationship with longtime adversary Iran. "I think a lot of great things are going to happen in the Middle East right now, and very importantly the oil (price) is plummeting and the stock market is shooting up like a rocket today," Trump said. He added, "The

Iran deal is going to bring a lot of success to the world."

Sealing an agreement before jetting off to the summit might change the dynamic of the gathering for Trump. He had friction with Macron, British PM Keir Starmer, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz and Italian PM Giorgia Meloni over failing to consult them before the decision to go to war.

Congratulating Trump, Macron said, "It's a very important matter for the peace of the whole world." Trump has pushed back on the four European leaders — members of the NATO alliance — for their lack of support for the US in the conflict. He's expected to discuss with leaders the demining of the Strait of Hormuz — quickly clearing them will be

crucial to regaining confidence of vessels. Macron Monday said France was ready to deploy within days assets, including mine-clearing vessels, to help.

Macron has invited leaders of three nations that aren't part of the G7 — Egypt, Qatar and the UAE — to take part in a session on the Middle East Tuesday, when Iran is likely to be a focus.

In another development, before heading to the summit, Trump told the *New York Post* he's warned Macron the US will "have no choice" but to slap 100% tariffs on French wines unless Paris removes digital tax on US tech firms — a threat that dates to his first administration. Macron said Monday it's not "for the US to decide what European or French law should be."

Social media ban for under-16s will give them back childhood: UK PM

More strict than in Australia, includes gaming platform, infinite scrolling

Paul Sandle & Sarah Young
London, June 15

British PM Keir Starmer said on Monday he would ban social media sites for under-16s and impose restrictions on gaming and live-streaming platforms, in a fightback against big tech that goes further than any other country.

The sweeping changes will "give kids their childhood back", Starmer said, outlining measures against Snapchat, TikTok, Instagram and other platforms, as well as gaming sites that allow strangers to contact children. "It is clear to me a full ban is the right choice," he said. "It will make a huge difference, it will



UK PM Keir Starmer at Downing Street on Monday. AP

make our children safer, it will make our children happier, it will give them more time, more security, more freedom to grow up, more opportunity".

However some experts doubted whether a blanket ban would be effective, and Starmer acknowledged it would be diffi-

cult to fully enforce such restrictions. Britain will go further than Australia — the first to ban social media for children — with controls on gaming platforms and possibility of overnight curfews and curbs on infinite scrolling for under-18s. YouTube, Facebook and X will be covered, the government said, but messaging services such as WhatsApp and Signal will not be.

"World-leading blocks" on livestreaming and strangers contacting children would also be imposed, Starmer said. "Is there a situation in the offline world where you would just let your child pair up with a stranger, an adult that you don't know anything about?" he said.

A ban could be in place next spring, he said, underpinned by existing powers and new regulations due by the end of the year.

REUTERS

TALKS COME AMID A LINGERING U.S. SECTION 301 PROBE ON INDIA'S INDUSTRIAL OVERCAPACITY

USTR heads to India on June 23 to give 'final touch' to trade deal

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 15

AFTER OVER a year of trade tensions between the US and India, United States Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer is headed to India to hold talks over two days with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal next week and give a final shape to the first tranche of the trade deal, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal said on Monday.

"USTR, as of now, is scheduled to visit India. On 23-24th, he will be engaging with Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal. Our expectation is that the discussion will be centred around giving final touches to the framework deal, which was discussed during the US team's visit in the first week of June, and also on the larger bilateral trade agreement being discussed between the two countries," Agarwal said.

This is the first instance when the US trade chief is expected to visit India since the negotiations for a trade deal began in February last year.

The US trade team to India for nearly half a dozen rounds of talks were headed by Brendan Lynch, Assistant United States Trade Representative for South and Central Asia.

However, Greer has been part of the trade delegation during negotiations with the EU and China. The talks come amid a lingering US Section 301 investigation on India's industrial overcapacity, which could result in additional tariffs on top of the 12.5% announced for the importation of goods produced using forced labour. Both these tariffs could come into effect next month and serve as the basis of a trade deal.

As India and the US inch closer to an agreement, trade data showed that bilateral trade is undergoing significant changes. While exports to the US in April and May surged by less than 1% to \$17.29 billion, imports registered a sharper jump by 19.40% to \$11.14 billion compared to April and May last year.

Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agarwal pointed out that India has significantly increased



While exports to US in April and May surged by less than 1% to \$17.29 bn, imports logged a sharper jump by 19.40% to \$11.14 bn. REUTERS

energy imports. Trade data also shows that the bilateral trade gap between the two countries has been shrinking.

Meanwhile, the ongoing US trade investigation has been a concern for the industry and foreign investors.

Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 gives Washington sweeping powers to not only impose tariffs but also the authority to impose non-tariff barriers,

which can restrict Indian exports to the US beyond goods.

Deborah Elms, Head of Trade Policy at Hinrich Foundation, has said the Section 301 could have a firmer legal standing and tariffs imposed could reach any level as long as the required procedures are followed. USTR started the investigation in March and has come out with the findings after the required duration. It has also al-

located time for public comments. "The courts, if asked to examine the use of Section 301, are likely to give the President wide deference as long as the required procedures are followed. Recall that the law provides maximum timelines, not any minimum. Past cases were often narrowly targeted. Future cases need not be so constrained. Tariffs may be part of any retaliatory package, set to any level, alongside a wide range of other actions to address the charge of unfair trade practices," Elms said.

Demands relating to market access for American agricultural products have been one of the biggest pressure points.

The India-US joint statement said that India will eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including dried distillers' grains, red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

LNG tanker Disha crosses Hormuz; 1st Indian ship to exit Persian Gulf in 2 mths

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 15

INDIAN LIQUEFIED natural gas (LNG) tanker Disha crossed the Strait of Hormuz on Monday amid the announcement that the US and Iran have reached a peace deal. Disha, which is operated and managed by state-owned Shipping Corporation of India (SCI), is the first Indian merchant vessel to cross the fraught waters of the strait in nearly two months. It is carrying Qatari LNG for India.

As per the ship tracking data and industry watchers, it is also the first vessel to cross the strait since the announcement of the peace pact, which is expected to be inked later this week. Shipping sector insiders say the shippers are eyeing the developments with caution, and traffic through the strait has not really picked up despite the announcement that a US-Iran deal has been worked out. Experts said it could take weeks for traffic through the strait to meaningfully pick up, and only if they feel assured that the peace deal will hold, given the experience of the past three months.

Carrying LNG for India's largest LNG importer Petronet LNG, the Malta-flagged Disha had been stranded in the Persian Gulf for over three months amid the West Asia war.

With Disha crossing the strait, the number of Indian vessels in the Persian Gulf, which is to the west of the strait, now stands at 13. Since early March, a total of 10 Indian vessels — of which nine were also India-flagged — have crossed the narrow waterway.

"As we speak now, LNG carrier Disha, managed by a Shipping Corporation of India-led consortium, has safely transited the Strait of Hormuz, and she is carrying 62,370 metric tonnes

• HORMUZ TRANSIT BY INDIAN SHIPS

CARRYING LNG for India's largest LNG importer Petronet LNG, the Malta-flagged Disha had been stranded in the Persian Gulf for over three months amid the war

WITH DISHA crossing the strait, the number of Indian vessels in the Persian Gulf, which is to the west of the Strait of Hormuz, now stands at 13

SINCE EARLY March, a total of 10 Indian vessels — of which nine were also India-flagged — have



crossed the narrow waterway that connects the Persian Gulf with Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea

of LNG cargo. The vessel is supposed to enter Dahej on coming to India, likely on the 18th (of June)," Shipping Ministry Director Opesh Kumar Sharma said. He added that the Centre stands ready to bring back the Indian ships stranded in the Persian Gulf whenever the strait opens and it is deemed safe for sailing, but didn't go into details of the preparation. As per vessel tracking data from MarineTraffic, Disha crossed the strait with the Automatic Identification System transponder on, broadcasting its location continuously. Most vessels that have crossed the strait in recent weeks have done so by switching off their transponders, or going dark, to avoid detection.

While a few Indian ships made their way through the strait over a weeks-long period starting mid-March due to diplomatic efforts by the Centre, transits of Indian and India-bound vessels came to a standstill after the April 18 incident in which a couple of Indian ships were fired upon by Iranian forces as they attempted to cross the waterway. One vessel — Desh Garima — man-

aged to slip out on April 18. The US also started its own blockade of Iranian ports mid-March, which worsened the maritime security scenario in the region. Since then, a few tankers carrying LPG, LNG, and crude oil for India did transit the strait, none of them were India-flagged or owned by Indian firms.

Iran suddenly closed the strait on April 18 — within a day of announcing unimpeded vessel movements through the waterway — leading to confusion among vessels that had lined up to cross it. This incident, and subsequent similar ones with Iran and the US running their own blockades, further hit the already constrained vessel movements.

Among the Indian vessels that have crossed the strait since early March are eight LPG tankers, one crude oil tanker, and one LNG tanker — Disha. A couple of Indian tankers also exited the war zone in this period, but they didn't have to cross the strait as they were already in the Gulf of Oman. One of them was loading at the UAE's Fujairah port when the oil terminal there came under attack.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FM: More measures to attract capital inflows on the anvil



“The withholding tax treatment which we offered, we think will be the first step towards drawing some capital back, although we have at the moment confined it only to bond market”

NIRMALA SITHARAMAN,
FINANCE MINISTER

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, June 15

INDIA WILL take more steps to spur foreign capital inflows, not stopping with the recent announcements made by the government and the RBI, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said Monday. "We will be doing more. We recognise we need more foreign capital to come in," she said at the Hero Mind Mine Summit in New Delhi.

On June 5, the government and RBI launched a coordinated, multi-pronged package to combat persistent foreign portfolio investor sell-offs, ease balance-of-payments (BoP) pressures, and stabilise the rupee.

Through an Ordinance, the government scrapped 20% withholding tax on interest income on government bonds and the 12.5% long-term capital gains (LTCG) tax on foreign bond holdings.

"The withholding tax treatment which we have offered, we think will be the first step towards drawing some capital back, although we have at the moment confined it only to the bond market. But certainly that is not the end of the story," Sitharaman said, hinting at measures aimed at boosting foreign investments in Indian equities as well.

FE reported earlier that the government internally discussed more than a dozen proposals to curb capital flight and address relatively low net FDI inflows, including a reduction in the long-term capital gains tax (LTCG) on equities. Additionally, to curb capital outflows, the government is also believed to be considering reducing the annual Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) limit from the current \$250,000 per individual. The limit could be temporarily halved, sources had said. FE

CHINA CONTROLS 90% OF GLOBAL CRITICAL MINERAL PROCESSING

US trade advocacy body forms task force on India-US critical mineral cooperation

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 15

DAYS AFTER India and the US signed a bilateral Critical Minerals Framework, the US-India Business Council (USIBC) formed a Critical Minerals Security Task Force aimed at deepening cooperation across critical mineral supply chains.

Cooperation between India and the US on critical minerals has gained impetus amid growing concerns over China's dominance on the supply chain which the latter often use as a leverage in trade disputes. Last year, Indian industry began

facing shortages of rare earth magnets when China launched a licensing regime, choking exports of rare earth elements during its trade war with the US.

While China controls 90% of global critical mineral processing, both India and the US are heavily dependent on their imports to meet their domestic demand. Highlighting overlapping interests of the two countries, USIBC said out of 30 minerals which India identifies as "critical", 26 overlap with the US priorities. These included rare earths, lithium, cobalt, nickel, graphite, gallium, tungsten, among others. The task force has

identified five priority areas for engagement: lithium refining and cathode active materials, recycling, feedstock corridors, synthetic graphite production for battery applications, and rare earth processing and magnet manufacturing.

Lithium refining is a key gap in India's battery supply chain, with the country currently possessing negligible refining capacity. As electric vehicle adoption is expected to accelerate in the coming years, building domestic capabilities in lithium refining and recycling is essential to reduce dependence on imports, particularly from China.

Meanwhile, rare earth permanent magnets are vital components for a range of sectors, like electric mobility, renewable energy, electronics, aerospace and defence. To strengthen domestic manufacturing in this segment, India has already announced a scheme to support 6,000 metric tonnes per annum of integrated REPM production capacity. On this front, the task force will focus on fostering technology partnerships, facilitating offtake commitments and integrating supply chains into shared end markets.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM